The Savior of the Gospel

Jesus Christ is supreme over creation as its Creator and Sustainer, supreme over the Church as its Head and the firstborn from the dead, and supreme in reconciliation — believers, already reconciled, will be presented holy and blameless as they continue in the faith.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8 **Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	**02 1:9–14** **Paul’s Prayer for the Colossians**	**03 1:15–23** **The Savior of the Gospel**	**04 1:24–29** **Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**
05 2:1–7 **The Believer’s Education**	**06 2:8–15** **Beware of Philosophy**	**07 2:16–23** **Run the Race Set Before You**	**08 3:1–11** **Looking Up, Putting Off**
09 3:12–17 **Service Manual for the Lord’s Army**	**10 3:18–4:1** **The Relationships of the New Man**	**11 4:2–6** **Perfecting the Prayer Life**	**12 4:7–18** **Portrait of a Ministry Team**

Christ first in everything

Colossians 1:15–23 · The commentary's outline

I. Christ and creation	II. Christ and the Church	III. Christ and the cross
Image of God · Firstborn over creation · Creator · Sustainer	Head of the body · Firstborn from the dead · Fullness of God · Reconciler	Requirement · Remedy · Reason · Condition for being presented
vv.15–17	vv.18–20	vv.21–23

"So that He Himself will come to have first place in everything" (v.18) — πρωτεύω, found only here in the NT.

Christ and creation, verse by verse

Colossians 1:15–17 · Outline I.A–D

v.15a	The picture of God — “the image of the invisible God”: He makes the unseen God seen (John 14:9)	**εἰκών** representation and manifestation
v.15b	Priority over creation — “firstborn”: the rank and rights of the heir, not the first created	**πρωτότοκος** preeminence (Ps 89:27)
v.16	Creator of the universe — heavens and earth, visible and invisible, thrones, dominions, rulers, authorities	**κτίζω** Aor. the act · Perf. the abiding result
v.17	Sustainer of the universe — “before all things, and in Him all things hold together”	**συνίστημι** Perf. — to stand together, cohere

The very angels the Colossians were tempted to worship (2:18) were created by Christ. They are creatures.

“Firstborn” and “only begotten”

Colossians 1:15b · Outline I.B — He has priority over creation

Firstborn
πρωτότοκος prōtotokos · G4416

- Stresses rank — the rights of the heir
- David made “firstborn,” though the youngest son (Ps 89:27)
- Israel called God’s firstborn (Exod 4:22)
- Christ is preeminent over all creation

vs

Only begotten
μονογενής monogenēs · John 3:16

- Stresses uniqueness
- Isaac, Abraham’s “only begotten son” (Heb 11:17) — though Abraham had other sons (Gen 25:1–2)
- Unique as the son of promise
- Jesus is the unique Son of God

If He created all things (v.16), He cannot Himself be a created thing.

Christ and the Church

Colossians 1:18–20 · Outline II.A–D

A Head of the body · v.18a

κεφαλή
Source of life and authority for the Church, the universal body all believers enter by Spirit baptism (1 Cor 12:13)

B Firstborn from the dead · v.18b

The first to rise to resurrection life, never to die again (Heb 2:14–15; 1 Cor 15:22–23)

C The fullness of God · v.19

πλήρωμα · κατοικέω
Not spread out among angels — permanently “at home” in Christ (2:9)

D Reconciler through the cross · v.20

ἀποκαταλλάσσω
Peace made “through the blood of His cross” — man reconciled to God, not God to man

“Reconcile all things” is not universal salvation: only those who believe are reconciled and have eternal life (John 3:16, 36).

Three sides of the atonement

Colossians 1:21–22a · Outline III.A–B — The requirement and remedy of the cross

Redemption sin-ward	**Reconciliation** man-ward	**Propitiation** God-ward
The price paid to free us Matthew 20:28	The barrier removed; we are brought back to God 2 Corinthians 5:18–20 “He has now reconciled you” (v.22)	God’s justice satisfied 1 John 2:2

“In His fleshly body through death” (v.22) — not a phantom body, not a mere man. The eternal Son died in real flesh.

Reconciled now — presented then

Colossians 1:22–23 · Outline III.C–D — The reason and the condition

Settled — not conditional
"He has now reconciled you" · v.22a

Past, complete and permanent

A gift received by faith (John 3:16)

Not dependent on a persevering life

vs

Conditional — the presentation
παρίστημι · ἀνέγκλητος · v.22b

To be presented holy, blameless, beyond reproach

"If indeed you continue in the faith" (v.23) — ei ge, first class condition

Linked with the Judgment Seat of Christ — reward, not eternal life

The "if" of verse 23 modifies "present," not "reconciled." The gift is secure; the presentation is the prize.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 1:15–23 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does verse 16 answer those who say “firstborn” means Christ was the first created being?

2. According to this study, what is conditional in verses 22–23, and what is not?

Apply

Give Christ First Place
Identify one area where Christ does not have first place and make one concrete change this week.

Reconciled Now, Presented Then
Name one influence that weakens your steadiness in the faith and take one step to limit it.

In one line: Christ is first in creation, first in the Church and first through the cross — and if He is all that, He is enough.